meeting to usher in the birth of a political alternative to the Congress, one that would be predicated on a Hindu cultural identity.

The national party was formed just four days before voting began in the new republic's first general election.[11] This political context was crucial. Three weeks earlier, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, speaking at Ludhiana's Dresi Maidan, had launched the Congress election campaign in Punjab, calling 'communalism the greatest enemy of the country' and rallying voters for an all-out 'war against communalism'. Addressing an audience of over a lakh people who had turned out to hear him in the 'mid-day heat', Nehru described the idea of a 'Hindu Rashtra' as 'fantastic' and 'ruinous'.

Anticipating the birth of the Jan Sangh, India's first prime minister 'appealed to the people not to lend their ears' to leaders of what he called 'communal organisations such as the Hindu Mahasabha, the RSS and the Jan Sangh'. These communal forces, he thundered, 'had reduced the Hindu religion to a "kitchen religion". For them, religion meant what one should eat and what not, and where and how.' In his 100-minute address, Nehru framed communalism as the greatest political question of the day. 'This fight against communalism is the foremost question before us today,' he declared. 'We cannot afford to make any compromise in this regard.'[12]

Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee, founding president of the Jan Sangh, stoutly denied the charge of communalism in his opening speech at the party's inaugural function. He stressed that the 'party would be open to Indians irrespective of caste and creed. The party would strive to ensure full protection and equal rights of citizenship to all minorities.'[13] Within two weeks, Mookerjee would be telling an audience in Calcutta's Deshpriya Park that his party was a 'sincere friend of Muslims'. Presaging L.K. Advani's charge of pseudo-secularism in the 1980s, he argued that the Congress could only look after Muslims through police and guns, but the Jan Sangh would see to their interests 'with love and sincerity of purpose'.[14] Nehru and Mookerjee had been cabinet colleagues for thirty-three months between August 1947 and April 1950, but clearly there had been no meeting of minds.